for a day, then for the rest of the session. In Delhi, BJP president J.P. Nadda wrote to Congress chief Mallikarjun Kharge questioning the party's "silence".

But it was facing more than political censure. Responding to a public interest litigation (PIL) filed by the AIADMK for a transfer of the probe in the matter to the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), the Madras High Court came down heavily on the Stalin government. Taking suo motu cognisance of the case, the National Human Rights Commission (NHRC), too, issued notice to the Tamil Nadu chief secretary and the director general of police, seeking a detailed report. On June 26, an investigation team of the National Commission for Women led by member Khushbu Sundar visited Kallakurichi.

Nor has Stalin been sitting idle. While talking tough against the Opposition, he set up a one-man commission of retired Madras HC judge B. Gokuldas on June 20 to recommend ways to prevent any recurrence of such incidents. The post-tragedy choreography duly rolled out: cash aid of Rs 10 lakh each to the bereaved families, Rs 50,000 to those being treated; the district collector transferred, the superintendent of police suspended; many of the accused nabbed.

But at the base of it all is poverty and those who seek relief from its grimness in cheap liquor. The state-owned Tamil Nadu State Marketing Corporation Limited (TASMAC) controls the wholesale and retail sale of liquor here. However, hooch is reportedly freely sold and consumed, its lower price as compared to TASMAC-sold liquor making it the preferred pick for those with limited means. "There is a huge trade network in illicit liquor, for rural weddings and other community gatherings. It's also consumed by some of those who are daily drinkers," says social commentator N. Sathia Moorthy.

But something went terribly wrong in Kallakurichi. Chemical analysis of the potion consumed on June 18 night allegedly revealed the use of methanol or methyl alcohol. The "deadly chemical" can cause high toxicity and metabolic acidosis, a condition in which the body produces excessive acid that the kidneys cannot flush out. Though brought under the ambit of the Tamil Nadu Prohibition Act in 2002, Kallakurichi shows the continuing availability of methanol.

THE DMK REGIME, FACING ALL-ROUND CENSURE, HAS SET UP A ONE-MAN COMMISSION TO PROBE THE TRAGEDY

Last year, 22 people had died in the Marakkanam and Madhuranthakam areas of north Tamil Nadu, and it was evident industrial methanol was being diverted to illicit liquor brewing. Referencing the incident, state BJP chief K. Annamalai said the DMK had not "learnt its lesson". The DMK's riposte was to cite police reports and claim the methanol supply actually came from BJP-ruled Puducherry.

Actor-politician Kamal Haasan was one who managed to think about the victims. After visiting those recovering at a hospital, he said: "I cannot say I have no sympathies for them. But they will have to understand they have been careless." A stupor of uncaring amnesia is what descends on the public too after every routine period of mourning and anger. ■

By Amitabh Srivastava

Tejaswi Yadav is at his combative best these days; he gives as good as he gets. This week, the Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) scion deftly turned the tables on Prime Minister Narendra Modi. During the protracted Lok Sabha poll campaign, Modi had frequently invoked Bihar's "jungle raj" under the 15-year reign of Tejaswi's father, Lalu Yadav, and his mother, Rabri Devi. Choosing the right moment for a riposte, the 34-year-old wrote on X: "Mr Prime Minister, see the jungle raj in Bihar in your era. The CBI team that reached Nawada to investigate the UGC-NET paper leak was attacked. Paper leak under your government, attack on CBI under your government and jungle raj someone else's?"

The natural air of confidence that the former deputy chief minister wears never seems an aberration—it is in the personality itself, but these days the circumstances are propitious too. Although the RJD secured only four Lok Sabha seats, narrowly missing out on three others, it garnered an impressive 9.6 million votes, up from 6.3 million votes in 2019. That made it the party with the highest vote count in Bihar. To be sure, this is partly the function of a larger battlefield footprint: the party contested 23 seats, four more than in 2019. But holding his own against the combined wiles of Chief Minister Nitish Kumar and the BJP's Chanakyas, Tejaswi has ended with more wind in his sail. The RJD now aims to capitalise on this momentum, with insiders confident that a victory in the assembly polls—slated for October 2025, but possibly sooner—is within reach.

But there's work to be done. On June 21, Tejaswi convened a marathon meeting of party leaders at his official residence in Patna. The message was unequivocal, especially for those who had failed to secure a lead for the party in their respective assembly segments—shape up or forfeit the chance of getting an assembly election ticket. In anticipation of a potential early election, Tejaswi instructed MLAs to hit the ground running, engage with the public and return with a status report within two months about what went wrong in places where